

Téa Wright

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Research Interests

Cognitively-inspired NLP, human-centric AI, interactive language acquisition, NLP for low-resource languages.

Education

University of California, Berkeley

Aug 2024 – Present

Ph.D. in Computer Science (Advisor: Alane Suhr)

Coursework: Natural Language Processing; Computer Vision; Learning and Decision Making; Data-centric LLMs; Large Scale VLA Models; Computational Models of Language Use; Deep Reinforcement Learning, Information Theory; Mind, Machine, and Meaning.

University of Colorado, Boulder

Aug 2020 – May 2024

B.S. in Computer Science

GPA: 4.00

Coursework: Natural Language Processing; Machine Learning and Linguistics; Machine Learning; Advanced Data Science; Artificial Intelligence; Algorithms; Cognitive Science; Robotics.

University of Carlos III, Madrid, Spain

Aug 2022 – Dec 2022

Education Abroad – Hispanic Studies

Research Experience

Graduate Student Researcher, Berkeley AI Research

Aug 2024 – Present

Advisor: Alane Suhr

- Developed an RL pipeline to align vision-language models (VLMs) as pragmatic interlocutors using gaze-based reward signals; demonstrated that grounding against human-like listener models significantly increases conversational human-likeness.
- Studied sample efficiency under realistic OCR degradations, systematically analyzing overlooked challenges such as poor segmentation or orthographic variations in low-resource OCR.
- Assisted in the design of a multi-modal dialogue corpus capturing collaborative problem-solving in grounded interactive games through data cleaning, dialogue-act and subtask annotation, and analyses.
- Analyzed base vs. instruction-tuned LLMs as human user simulators on task-oriented dialogue corpora, demonstrating that base models better preserve diversity and human-likeness over instruction-tuned models.

Undergraduate Research Assistant, NALA Lab

Jun 2023 – May 2024

Advisors: Katharina von der Wense, Alexis Palmer, James Martin

- Developed automatic metrics for contextual support in LLM-generated stories to support preschool vocabulary learning.
- Explored effects of OCR quality on encoder-only model adaptation for Lakota. Documented linguistic resources and defended a thesis.

Grants and Awards

- NSF Graduate Research Fellowship (2025–)
- UC Berkeley Chancellor’s Fellowship (2024–2025)
- CU Boulder Graduating Student Research Award (2024)
- CU Boulder Chancellor’s Recognition Award (2024)
- CRA Outstanding Undergraduate Research Award – Honorable Mention (2023–2024)
- Joseph A. Sewall Award, Sewall Esteemed Scholars Program (2020–2024)

Publications

- **Téa Wright**, Alane Suhr. *Learning to Refer from Estimated Listener Gaze*. COLM 2026.
- Maria Valentini, **Téa Wright**, Julisa Granados, Eliana Colunga, Katharina von der Wense. *An Investigation of Translationese in the Generations of Multilingual Large Language Models*. COLM 2026.
- Skye Gunasekaran, **Téa Wright**, Rui-Jie Zhu, Jason Eshraghian. *Transformers with Selective Access to Early Representations*. TMLR 2026.
- Minwoo Kang, **Téa Wright**, Seun Eisape, Ayush Raj, Suhong Moon, Joseph Suh, Alane Suhr, David M. Chan. *Pretrained Persona Mixture Models and Tandem Models for Human Simulation*. Preprint 2026.
- Nicholas Tomlin, Naitian Zhou, Eve Fleisig, Liangyuan (Circle) Chen, **Téa Wright**, Lauren Vinh, Laura X. Ma, Seun Eisape, Ellie French, Tingting Du, Tianjiao Zhang, Alexander Koller, Alane Suhr. *Characterizing Language Use in a Collaborative Situated Game*. Preprint 2025.
- Maria Valentini*, **Téa Wright***, Ali Marashian, Jennifer Weber, Eliana Colunga, Katharina von der Wense. *Measuring Contextual Informativeness in Child-Directed Text*. COLING 2025.
- Jennifer Weber, Maria Valentini, **Téa Wright**, Katharina von der Wense, Eliana Colunga. *Evaluating LLMs as Tools to Support Early Vocabulary Learning*. CogSci 2024.
- Maria Valentini, Jennifer Weber, Jesus Salcido, **Téa Wright**, Eliana Colunga, Katharina von der Wense. *On the Automatic Generation and Simplification of Children's Stories*. EMNLP 2023.

Leadership & Volunteering

Reviewer, COLM Workshops 2025, COLM Workshops 2026, Nature 2026

Workshop Organizer – Workshop on Learning from Situated and Embodied Interaction (LSEI) – COLM 2026, Workshop on Pragmatic Reasoning in Language Models: Language Models as Language Users (PragLM) – COLM 2025

Advisory Board Member – Coalition for Language Equity in AI Research (CLEAR)

Admissions Reviewer, UC Berkeley (Jan 2025)

Volunteer, COLING 2025, EMNLP 2023

Talks

Learning to Refer from Estimated Listener Gaze, BerkeleyNLP Workshop

Oct 2026

Mentorship

Laura Ma (2025-2026) → Georgetown University MS

Technical Skills

Languages: Python, C++, HTML/CSS

ML Tools: PyTorch, Hugging Face (Transformers, PEFT, Accelerate), vLLM

Data Science: NumPy, Pandas, scikit-learn, Matplotlib

Infrastructure: Git, Linux, Conda, W&B, Slurm

Languages

English (Fluent), Spanish (Conversational), Japanese (Conversational), Korean (Beginner)

Hobbies

Language learning, fashion, piano, travel, hiking, mountain biking